

Who Keeps the Most Important Part of Learning?

There is a moment in Chapter 4 of Rosenberg's Life-Enriching Education that I keep returning to. It comes from a story about Carl Rogers, who opened a psychotherapy class by simply waiting - waiting for students to say what they actually wanted to learn. When a student challenged this, Rogers replied that if he alone decided what was worth learning, he would be "reserving the most important part of learning" for himself every single day. That sentence landed somewhere uncomfortable for me, and I think that discomfort is worth examining.

I have very limited teaching experience, but there is one session I remember clearly. I was tutoring a student in English, and I had prepared a lesson on past tenses - past simple, past continuous, the whole structure. I felt reasonably confident about the material, I had a sequence in mind, and I followed it. The lesson went well enough, in the sense that the student was engaged and we covered what I had planned. It was only at the very end, almost as an afterthought, that the student mentioned he had a test the following day - on something entirely different. I stayed longer to help him prepare, but the damage was done: I had spent the session teaching what I thought he needed, without ever asking what he actually needed right now.

Reading Rosenberg helped me understand why this happened, and it was not simply a matter of bad planning. The assumption I carried into that session - that I, as the one who prepared, was the appropriate person to set the agenda - is exactly what Rosenberg calls the domination model: the teacher knows what the student needs, and the student's role is to follow. I was not being malicious, and I do not think I was being arrogant in any dramatic sense. But I was, to use Rogers' formulation, keeping the most important part of learning for myself. The student never had a chance to say what mattered to him that day.

What Rosenberg proposes instead is what he calls Life-Enriching Education, where learning objectives are reached mutually - neither the teacher dictating nor the student simply doing whatever they want, but a genuine negotiation where both parties commit to something they both see value in. This sounds idealistic, and I will admit I am not entirely sure how it works in every context, particularly with younger learners or within fixed curricula. But the

principle underneath it resonates with me, especially his point that students always have a choice anyway. The 30 percent absent rate at the school in his anecdote makes this painfully literal: if you do not give students meaningful reasons to engage, they will simply leave - physically or mentally.

I also find myself drawn to Rosenberg's critique of grades, which connects to the same underlying problem. If a student is working toward a shared, clearly defined objective, evaluation becomes almost natural - did we get there or not? But when objectives are vague and unilaterally imposed, grades become a kind of social punishment for failing to meet someone else's unstated expectations. I have been on the receiving end of that system for most of my academic life, and I recognise the anxiety it produces. What strikes me now, standing on the other side of the classroom for the first time, is how easily I reproduced the same logic without noticing.

I am not sure I will always have the time or the conditions to negotiate objectives the way Rosenberg describes. But I think the habit I want to build is simpler than the full NVC framework: ask first. Not as a formality, but with genuine curiosity about where the student is and what they actually need from this session. That one question - asked before the lesson rather than after - would have changed everything about the session I described. It would also have kept the most important part of learning where it belongs: with the person who is doing it.